

The East Anglian Gin Economy

How Much Land Would Britain Need to Grow the Botanicals and Grain for Its Gin?

Following the beer and Walkers potato analysis, gin is an interesting case because it is **much less land-intensive** than beer or crisps. The economic opportunity is not primarily agricultural volume; it is **turning relatively small amounts of agricultural output into very high-value branded exports**.

East Anglia is particularly interesting because it already has:

- huge arable production
- grain-growing infrastructure
- ports for export
- historic links with agriculture and distilling

The East of England has approximately **1.4 million hectares of farmland**, with around **80% classified as arable**. It is one of Britain's most productive farming regions, producing large amounts of wheat, barley, sugar beet and potatoes.

1. How Much Gin Does Britain Drink?

The UK gin market experienced a major expansion during the "gin renaissance".

Recent estimates put UK gin consumption at approximately:

68 million bottles per year

(70cl bottles)

The market peaked around 96 million bottles during the pandemic period before declining.

Therefore:

68 million × 0.7 litres

=

47.6 million litres of gin annually

2. Gin Consumption Per Person

Population:

≈ 68 million people

Therefore:

47.6 million litres ÷ 68 million

=

0.7 litres per person per year

Equivalent:

Around 1 bottle per person per year

However, like beer, this average includes:

- children
 - non-drinkers
 - people who never drink spirits
-

3. Gin Consumption Among Spirit Drinkers

Assume:

40 million alcohol consumers.

47.6 million litres ÷ 40 million

=

1.2 litres per drinking adult per year

Equivalent:

Approximately:

1.7 bottles per drinker annually

4. What Is Gin Made From?

Gin is fundamentally:

- neutral spirit
- juniper
- botanicals

The key agricultural input is usually:

Grain → neutral alcohol → gin

Most industrial neutral spirit comes from:

- wheat
- barley
- maize

The botanicals are tiny quantities.

5. Grain Required for British Gin

A typical assumption:

1 tonne of grain produces roughly:

400 litres of pure alcohol

A standard gin:

37.5% ABV

Therefore:

1 litre gin contains:

0.375 litres alcohol

47.6 million litres gin requires:

$47.6\text{m} \times 0.375$

=

17.8 million litres of pure alcohol

Grain requirement:

$17.8\text{m} \div 400$

=

approximately 45,000 tonnes of grain

6. Land Requirement

Assume wheat yield:

8 tonnes/hectare

Therefore:

45,000 tonnes $\div$ 8

=

5,600 hectares

Result:

To grow enough grain for all UK gin production:

Around 5,000–6,000 hectares

would be required.

That is:

Less than 0.05% of UK agricultural land

7. Botanicals: The Juniper Question

The grain is actually the large agricultural input.

Juniper requirement is tiny.

A typical gin may use:

$\approx$ 10–30 grams of juniper berries per litre.

Assume:

20g per litre.

47.6 million litres $\times$ 20g

=

952 tonnes of juniper berries

Even if grown domestically, this is a small agricultural requirement.

The UK could theoretically establish:

- managed juniper plantations
- hedgerow production

- upland botanical farms

without significant land competition.

8. East Anglia Gin Opportunity

East Anglia has a unique advantage.

It can supply:

Grain

↓

Distillery

↓

Premium gin

↓

Export product

The region already has:

- wheat production
- agricultural skills
- ports
- logistics

East Anglia contains around **397,000 hectares of wheat** and **206,000 hectares of barley**, showing the scale of its cereal economy.

A gin industry would use only a tiny fraction of this.

9. The Marginal Cost Argument

The raw agricultural cost is almost irrelevant to the final bottle price.

Example:

Wheat

1 tonne:

≈ £150–£250

↓

Neutral spirit

Higher value

↓

Gin

Retail bottle:

£25–£50+

The economics are:

Commodity agriculture:

low margin

↓

Processing

higher margin

↓

Brand

very high margin

10. Why Gin Is Attractive Compared With Beer

Product	Raw agricultural requirement	Value added
Beer	~1.1m tonnes barley	Medium
Crisps	~290k tonnes potatoes	High
Gin	~45k tonnes grain	Very high

Gin uses much less land but creates enormous value per tonne of agricultural input.

11. The East Anglia Premium Spirits Cluster

A strategic investment fund could build:

East Anglia Spirits Corridor

Assets:

Agricultural

- wheat farms
- barley farms
- botanical farms

Manufacturing

- distilleries
- bottling plants
- warehouses

Tourism

- distillery tours
- farm experiences
- food tourism

Export

Using:

- Felixstowe
 - London logistics
 - international distribution
-

12. Export Opportunity

Premium British gin has strong international appeal.

Potential markets:

- United States
- Japan
- Singapore
- Australia
- Gulf states
- Europe

The strategy:

Do not export grain.

Do not export alcohol.

Export:

A British agricultural luxury brand.

13. Investment Thesis

A sovereign-style agricultural investment strategy would not focus on growing more grain.

It would focus on owning the value chain:

East Anglia Farms

↓

Grain Supply

↓

Malt / Neutral Spirit

↓

Gin Distillery

↓

Premium Brand

↓

Global Export

Conclusion

Britain's entire gin industry could theoretically be supplied from only around:

5,000–6,000 hectares of arable land

A tiny fraction of East Anglia's agricultural capacity.

The lesson is similar to Walkers Crisps and beer:

The economic opportunity is not in producing more raw crops. It is in converting Britain's agricultural abundance into branded, exportable products.

East Anglia could therefore become a **British spirits manufacturing region** — combining its existing farming base with high-value distilling, tourism and export industries.